pandemic did not help. But had the economy been on the up, or even on an even keel, perhaps the rest of the governance problems would not have taken on the larger-than-life proportion as they eventually did. At some point, the military decided it had had enough of hand-holding Imran, especially because the public brickbats were being as much directed towards the army as at the civilian façade.

IMRAN'S RIFT WITH THE MILITARY

Aside from the general resentment from average folks over the state of inflation and unemployment—often conveyed to enlisted personnel when they returned to their hometowns—the army received a rude shock when former prime minister Nawaz Sharif and his daughter Maryam Nawaz began to pointedly target the army leadership by name in late 2020.

In particular, the naming of the army chief, Gen. Qamar Javed Bajwa, and ISI head Lt Gen. Faiz Hameed as those responsible for installing and propping up Imran caused much consternation within the military. Not only was it unprecedented for Pakistani politicians to take on the military in such specific terms, of particular concern to Imran's backers was how much the populist speeches resonated within Punjab, Pakistan's largest province by population—almost 60 per cent of the country's total. It is well established that winning Punjab is key for any democratically elected government. It has also often been characterised as being docile to power—most of the military personnel also originate from the province. For Punjab to be seething with discontent set alarm bells ringing in the corridors of power. The military had long been quietly urging Imran to change his handpicked chief minister of Punjab, Usman Buzdar. Imran had plucked Buzdar out of obscurity and appointed him the chief executive of the province in 2018, much to the surprise of everyone, including his own party members. Hailing from an underdeveloped area of the province and not a member of the PTI before the 2018 election, Buzdar was seen as inexperienced and ineffective and made the contrast between the previous CM Shehbaz Sharif—seen as a doer with a strong grip over the administration—appear even starker.

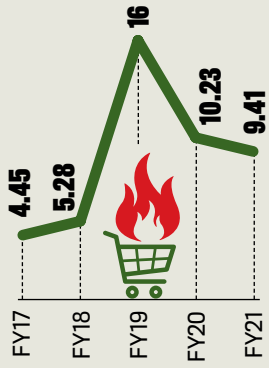
IMRAN'S REAL RUPTURE WITH THE ARMY TOOK PLACE LAST YEAR, WHEN HE RESISTED GEN. BAJWA'S ATTEMPT TO MOVE LT GEN. HAMEED OUT OF THE ISI. HE HAD CROSSED A RED LINE

The military felt Buzdar was losing Punjab. But despite its continuous urging and rising disaffection within the PTI, Imran refused to budge on his choice and even called Buzdar "Waseem Akram Plus"—a reference to Imran's one-time fast bowling protege. There was widespread speculation that the appointment had more to do with Imran's wife Bushra's 'spiritual guidance' and alleged occult practices—a charge Imran strenuously denies. Nevertheless, the friction on this issue continued to linger and grow. As it happened, when push came to shove in the recent crisis, Imran did finally

PAKISTAN: AN ECONOMY IN DOLDRUMS

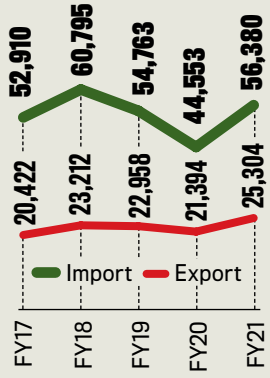
SOARING INFLATION

Wholesale Price Inflation



NEGATIVE TRADE BALANCE

Trade balance
($ million)



CRASHING PAKISTANI RUPEE

Exchange rate
(Pakistani Rs per US $, yearly average)

